Doc Brackett

By Damon Runyon

INTRODUCTION

Popular culture presents a variety of mythic frontier doctors, like Doc Baker from the 1970s television series Little House on the Prairie, galloping across the prairie to save young Billy or help Ma deliver a baby at the Nelson farm. In many ways, the myth was real. Most country doctors lived in town and traveled widely to visit sick patients on their homesteads.

Doc Brackett speaks to the strong (almost religious) beliefs about the power of medicine in American culture. In a culture whose main values are narcissism and materialism, medicine appears to hold the "keys to the kingdom" once held by religion. On a more personal level, the story symbolizes the experience of being a healer at any time or place. The sick are needy, vulnerable, and sometimes demanding; the physician is only human, can only accomplish so much. Doc Brackett by Damon Runyon.

Doc Brackett was a fine man. He doctored in our town for many years. He doctored more people than any other doctor in our town but made less money. That was because Doc Brackett was always doctoring poor people, who had no money to pay.

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He would get up in the middle of the coldest night and ride twenty miles to doctor a sick woman or child or to patch up some fellow who got hurt. Everybody in our town knew Doc Brackett's office was over Rice's clothing store. It was up a narrow flight of stairs. His office was always filled with people. A sign at the foot of the stairs said: "DR. BRACKETT, OFFICE UPSTAIRS"

Doc Brackett was a bachelor. He was once supposed to marry Miss Elvira Cromwell, the daughter of old Julius Cromwell, the banker. But, on the day the wedding was supposed to take place Doc Brackett got a call to go out into the country and doctor a Mexican child.

Miss Elvira got sore at him and called off the wedding. She said that a man who would think more of a Mexican child than of his wedding was no good. Many women in our town agreed with Miss Elvira Cromwell, but the parents of the Mexican child were very grateful to Doc Brackett when the child recovered.

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For forty years the lame and the halt and the blind of our town had climbed up and down the stairs to Doc Brackett's office. He never turned away anybody. He lived to be seventy years old and then one day he just keeled over on the sofa and died. By this time his black hair had turned white. Doc Brackett had one of the biggest funerals ever seen in our town. Everybody went to pay their last respects when he was laid out in Grubers undertaking parlor. He was buried in Riverview Cemetery.

There was talk of raising money to put a nice tombstone on Doc Brackett's grave as a memorial. The talk got as far as arguing about what should be carved on the stone about him. Some thought poetry would be very nice. Doc Brackett hated poetry. The matter dragged along and nothing whatever was done.

Then, one day George Gruber, the undertaker, said that Doc Brackett's memorial was already over his grave,

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with epitaph and all. George Gruber said the parents of the Mexican child that Doc Brackett had saved years ago had worried about him having no tombstone. They had no money themselves, so they took the sign from the foot of the stairs at Doc Brackett's office and stuck it over his grave. It read: "DR. BRACKETT, OFFICE UPSTAIRS."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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